



Introduction to the special issue

Populism in the era of Twitter: How social media contextualized new insights into an old phenomenon

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Abstract

With the advent of social media, political communication scholars have systematically revised theories and empirical corollaries revolving media use and democracy at large. Interestingly, in about the same period of time, a reinvigorated political populism trend has taken place across different latitudes in the world. This widespread populist movement has expanded regardless of whether these political systems were established democracies, emerging democracies, or societies immersed in political contexts at peril. This essay serves as the introductory piece to a special issue on *populism*. First, it highlights the ways in which “populism,” being an old phenomenon, has further transpired into the political realm in the era of social media. Second, the essay seeks to better contextualize what populism is and how it has developed within today’s hybrid media society. Finally, this introduction also lays out the ground to six central theoretical and data-driven papers that encapsulate many of the important issues revolving the phenomenon of *populism* today.

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In this essay, we introduce a set of theoretical and empirical studies delving on *populism*. The special volume focuses on how populists actually connect with citizens, what communication strategies they use, and how these differ from communication modes and styles we know from established candidates/parties. Do populists have their own way of communicating? How do they shape political discussions in the online and offline world? And what are the broader implications for future political campaigns, the state of a buoyant public sphere, and for a healthier democracy at large?

Over the past decades, the world has witnessed a growing wave of populism that has made significant electoral gains across the globe. This populist surge encompasses a broad ideological spectrum at both sides of the political aisle in the United States (i.e. *progressive* and *conservative*), in Europe and Latin America (*right* and *left*), and elsewhere. Many recent results at national general elections attested this current tendency. For instance, the election of Donald Trump in the United States in 2016, the entry of the Alternative for Germany (AfD) into the German parliament in 2017, the election of Sebastian Kurz in 2017 as Austria's Chancellor, the election of Bolsonaro as Brazil's president with more than 50% of the popular vote in 2018, or the many existing populist forces gaining momentum in referendums and elections across Europe and Latin America suggest that populism is on the rise. This widespread of populism has also sparked scholarly attention which has exponentially increased in recent years (De Vreese, Esser, Aalberg, and Reinemann Stanyer, 2018; Engesser et al., 2017; Kaltwasser, 2015; Norris and Inglehart, 2019; Wettstein et al., 2019).

What is populism?

Populism as a concept is widely used but also extensively contested (Gidron and Bonikowski, 2013). In the absence of a solid, holistic, and systematic theory and definition of populism, the term has loosely been used as a synonym for anti-establishment narrative (Müller, 2016). Thus, populism may be understood as a set of generally demagogic ideas and as a political communicational strategy. Political populism prospers as an anti-establishment pursuit led by a charismatic leader, praising the role of "the people" and aiming to dichotomize the political arena and society into "us, the people," versus "them, the elites." This clear in-group versus out-group (Falk et al., 2012) strategy may be employed by sharply distinct political parties and their leaders, but it may also be practiced by different actors (i.e. political institutions, the media, etc.). While there are several examples of populist leaders,¹ there is no overall blueprint for a typical populist leader.² "Populist" as a label has rarely been self-attributed or claimed by individuals or organizations. A notable exception, however, is Le Pen in France who self-proclaimed to be a populist leader (Stanley, 2008). Overall, the term populism usually originates from a negative ascription by political opponents or the media (Wettstein et al., 2018).

Background

The literature on populism broadly suggests three successive waves of this phenomenon: agrarian populism, Latin American populism, and the new-right populism (Jagers and Walgrave, 2007). Its first manifestations emerged in Russia and the United States during the second half of the 19th century. The second wave of populism began in the 1930s in Latin America, when authoritarian regimes centered on a charismatic leader were established in Argentina and Brazil, claiming to be a direct representation of the people, acting in their best interest and against the establishment (Hennessy, 1969). The third wave is embodied by the recent rise of populism movements from the 1970s onwards. Established mainstream parties, especially across Europe and the United States were increasingly perceived as self-serving and ignorant toward the demands and needs of “the people” (Gidron and Bonikowski, 2013; Kazin, 1998; Taggart, 2000).

Although this recent wave has typically been associated with radical right-wing movements, populism may be now also distributed within the ideological spectrum. Be it ideologically connected to the right or the left, populism is rather linked to the level of radicalism of the party or candidate (Rooduijn and Akkerman, 2017). On one hand, right-wing populism commonly identifies with topics such as immigration, taxes, crime, and nationalism (Taggart, 2000). On the contrary, radical left movements initially focused on pre-USSR collapse, criticizing capitalism and neoliberalism, and progressively transitioned to include a broader scope of social topics (March and Mudde, 2005). Previous work argues that populism is a direct response to liberal democracies neglecting the founding idea of popular sovereignty, offering the analogy of a “drunken guest at a dinner party” blurting out the inconvenient truths that highlight the distance between regular citizens and the politics, and institutions that govern them (Huber and Schimpf, 2016: 103). In any case, populism and populists’ parties and elected figures have become a central part of contemporary politics (Moffitt and Tormey, 2014).

Populism in the era of Twitter

Some scholars warned about how online communication ecosystems could open the door not only to polarizing or uncivil messages (Coe et al., 2014; Lawrence et al., 2010; Rains et al., 2017; Wu, 2013) but also to populist messages (Bobba and Legnante, 2017; Schroeder, 2018). In the days of a hybrid media system with pervasive social media interactions intertwined with professional journalism (Bruns, 2018; Chadwick, 2017), populism has thrived (Wells et al., 2016). It is important to stress that populism as a thin ideology (Ernst et al., 2017), core strategy to influence the public (Mazzoleni, 2014), and as an extreme left-/right-wing leadership-dependent phenomenon (Mudde and Kaltwasser, 2014; Van der Brug and Mughan, 2007) has remained constant and unaltered. However, social media has inflicted and sustained a pivotal playing role in the way populists’ campaigns are carried out and the ways political actors communicate and directly engage with the electorate. First, social media provides “low cost” communication opportunities (Bennett, 2012) and potential for broad and rapid dissemination of messages (Ratkiewicz et al., 2011). Ernst et al. (2017) talk about the virality effect. Accordingly, political leaders may not be able to solely achieve their goal by having

social media access in one or many platforms, but rather by increasing their reliance on strong interconnected networks of citizens that by commenting, promoting, and discussing their original messages, directly participate in the profound dissemination of these populist ideas. Prior research has also identified that for a message to become viral, it has to incorporate certain elements such as emotional attachment, novel and surprising information, fuel passive broadcasting, and seek message personalization (Aral and Walker, 2011; Hong et al., 2011). All features are deeply exploited by populists' politicians. The more direct, unmediated, outrageous, polarizing, shocking, and emotional the message is, the more chances of becoming viral and *populistically* effective. It is a victory for populists' politicians at the expense of debilitating a civil, constructive, and rational public sphere. Informative public affair facts and the pursuit of a common goal in society may thus become irrelevant.

When truth becomes irrelevant

In recent years, we have witnessed political discourses and debates in which facts have lost their meaning as benchmarks for evaluations and decisions, and became a flexible tool to reinforce certain worldviews (Maurer and Reinemann, 2006; Ryan and Gamson, 2006). As an exemplary token, let us select a photo used in flyers about domestic security distributed by the far-right party AfD in Germany. The original picture was taken in Athens during a riot and shows a protestor hitting a police officer with a stick. The edited picture showed the protestor with a logo-badge from the German Antifa, an anti-fascist network. It was an obvious fake. When asked for a clarification, an AfD spokesman claimed that a fake photo would not change the fact that the security situation in Germany was getting worse and that, captured in the photo or not, it is obvious who is responsible for the rise of violence in the country. Evidence and facts are now seemingly irrelevant and have turned out to be something adjustable to a political cause. The former Princeton University philosophy professor Harry Frankfurt (2009) calls this *bullshit*. A lie can be answered with evidence, which forces the liar to revise or withdraw former statements. Bullshit cuts out unwelcome facts: evidence that supports the message is true, evidence that hinders it is false (Frankfurt, 2009). The principle of truth loses its relevance, and this is paramount for democracies. At the heart of democracy is the debate, the discourse about political alternatives based on facts, despite ideological differences. When citizens and politicians do not engage in a fact-driven discourse any more, democracy is at peril.

Volume research highlights

The research included in this current Special Issue proposes a set of theoretical and data-driven papers that encapsulate many of the important issues revolving the phenomenon of "populism" today. It starts with a theoretical manuscript by Gibson and Roemmele (2019) developing the concept of the *fourth era of political campaigning* emerging within the Western democracies. Following this theoretical piece, this volume includes four empirically based studies depicting some of the key elements showcased in the fourth campaigning era. Jacob et al. (2020) look at the role of social media platforms, specifically Facebook and Twitter, in shaping populist communication strategies. Bucy

et al. (2020) focus on the populist styles of communication employed by candidates and the responses they induce on social media. Wells et al. (2020) seek to understand the relationship between populists and traditional media. Finally, Boulianne et al. (2020) investigate the propensity of voters to turn toward populist candidates due to their usage of offline and online media, social media, and the possible echo chamber effects. The Special Issue concludes as it started, with a theoretical essay by Bimber and Gil de Zúñiga (2020) that centers on the challenges brought upon by the development of social media and some populist communication strategies to the existence of the public sphere within democratic regimes.

Gibson and Roemmele (2020) offer a stimulating proposition that illustrates tangible deep transformations of previous, post-modern, types of campaigning as they shifted into a new stage. This new campaign era includes indirect systematic ways of communication with the constituencies, and it is chiefly based on a two-step model. It intensively employs the in-house technological infrastructure as political parties amass and curate large amounts of data, openly available in social media.

Accordingly, modern political campaigning allows the proliferation of extensive databases for psychometrical profiling of the voters and micro-targeting, but also leaves an open space for cyber-attacks from the opposition, and beyond. Depending on how those elements are curated and handled by parties or candidates, campaigns may turn toward two distinct directions: “scientific” or “subversive.” Based on the same principles—data-driven, using virtual networks and high level of personalization—these two campaign types differ in content, procedures, and goals. The former tends to align much more with a traditional format of political campaigning. “Subversive” campaigning, on the other hand, seeks to recognize the recent success of populist movements in Western democracies. Subversive mode focuses on the role of strong leader, often outsider to mainstream politics, whose actions are funneled by data and “the views of the people.” Yet, its personality and behavior may become erratic, overpowering and seemingly spontaneous. Such a guru-like leadership requires specific staff members, where loyalty may be more relevant than field expertise, and strong ideological orientations are well received over a more nuanced and balanced view of traditional political advisors. From the communication perspective, subversive campaigning engages ad hoc messages, often intended at misinformation and polarization of the voters, turning them emotionally against the opposition or intentionally demobilizing them. Social media, as network-based and direct communication tools, is tuned in as a machine against the establishment and traditional media reporting.

Jacobs et al.’s (2020) study explores the different communication strategies adopted and employed by populist and non-populist Members of Parliament in Austria, The Netherlands, and Sweden. They argue these strategies are also platform dependent as they theorize the existence of two distinct practices in social media. On Twitter, *@name&shame* messages are to pressure journalists to increase media coverage. On Facebook, posts by politicians are to *activate anger* among followers by engaging a sense of injustice and cultural backlash. Counterintuitively, the study finds that MPs representing populist parties are in general less likely to have a social media account. Yet, their employment of *@name&shame* strategy is three times higher than non-populist politicians. Similarly, their postings on Facebook are substantially more geared at

eliciting anger-based reactions. Thus, through emotions, they try to attract more attention to their messages and further engage the electorate.

Bucy et al. (2020) offer a case study analysis of the first 2016 presidential debate between Hilary Clinton and Donald Trump seeking to understand how the specific styles of populist discourse generate real-time reactions on Twitter. These scholars focus on the transgressive communication style represented by Trump, violating the normative boundaries, openly displaying frustration and anger. This populist style is operationalized by *emotionalization*, *simplification*, and *negativity* estimated within verbal, tonal, and non-verbal communication. The paper shares with *New Media & Society* readers an original extensive coding schema. The results are intuitive; however, the intensity of the effects may come as a surprise. Trump employed anger or threat almost along his entire discourse, especially nonverbal facial expressions. The current president of the United States added defiance visual cues and gestures in about more than half of his speaking time. He engaged more vigorously into personal attacks, blaming others of hostile interruptions. His populist style discourse stimulated those viewers who second screened the debate via Twitter (to learn more about second screening or dual screening; see, for instance, Gil de Zúñiga and Liu, 2017; Gil de Zúñiga, García-Perdomo, and McGregor, 2015; Vaccari et al., 2015). The tweet flow was faster and more persistent in time for Trump's interventions than for those of Clinton, and all visual populist indicators facilitated the online responses more rapidly than any other populist features (i.e. tonal or verbal).

Wells et al.'s (2020) study, similar to Jacobs et al.'s (2020), seeks to depict paramount communication strategy features of the main candidates in US 2016 primary elections. The authors pay special attention to two of the most populist candidates, Trump and Sanders, and how they *attract attention* from diverse media outlets. The research, theoretically grounded in attention economy framework, delves into how disaggregated media outlets in America covered candidates, and how those candidates employed diverse techniques (i.e. events and social media) to attract media interest. Findings are mixed, although tend to be more consistent for Republican candidates. For instance, Trump benefits from retweets, special events like debates, and the relative strong standing garnished in public opinion polls to bust *biased* interest of mainstream professional media. Interestingly, Sanders kept pace with Trump in the number of retweets, yet he did not receive similar media coverage. These results do not entirely lend support to consistent effects of populists' messages and strategies, and leave room for future research to further understand the unbalanced interest and attentiveness of the contemporary media ecology toward left- and right-wing populism. Finally, and perhaps contrary to popular belief, the study reveals a planned and strategic usage of Twitter by Trump as he tweeted relatively more intensively when media attention to his rhetoric declined.

Boulianne et al.'s (2019) research challenges a commonly argued claim that social media helps to bypass traditional media (for a discussion of changing gatekeeping practices, see Coddington and Holton, 2014), eliciting efficient mobilization of right-wing populist parties' voters. Specially, they concentrate on the concept of echo chambers and the extent to which closing within similar views offline and online brings support for populism. The article is based on an original representative survey data set collected in France, the United Kingdom, and the United States. These authors found little evidence for the impact of social media use, or any other media, on the propensity to vote

right-wing populists. Similarly, they do not confirm the hypothesis about the creation of online echo chambers, measured through political discussion networks that receive homogeneous information. On the contrary, they found a consistent offline homogeneous discussion network pattern (i.e. those similar in race, ethnicity, and social class) revolving the right-wing populist vote, particularly in France and the United Kingdom.

Finally, the Special Issue concludes by showcasing some of the most pressing issues in today's democracy upstretched by all recent technological changes, contributing to *the unedited public sphere*. In this theoretical account, Bimber and Gil de Zúñiga (2019) offer new perspectives and directions revolving the relation between political actors and their employment of social media affordances. They draw on a "false beliefs paradigm," and lay out three epistemic features on how current digital technology and social media ecosystems are concentrating on (1) obscuring the provenance of information, (2) facilitating deception about authorship, and (3) securing the manipulation of social signals. Systematically, the essay explains how these three epistemic problems tend to guarantee people's disability to discern what is true and what is not in the flow of political communication through mass media channels, as well as through social media tools. The article highlights the importance of future research in clarifying how epistemic challenges brought by social media may affect the exercising of democracy and the transformation of public spheres within the "post-truth politics" era. In doing so, the authors attempt to map out some of these potential research lines and suggest some remedies geared toward fostering healthier democracies.

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Notes

1. As mentioned earlier, Vargas, Peron, Ibarra, and Estenssoro, in the Latin American context, have strongly influenced the image of the charismatic, rhetorically well-versed "demagogue" that often is associated with the image of a for populist leaders.
2. Despite the absence of an overall definition, scholars like Mudde and Kaltwasser (2017) identify different manifestations of this phenomenon such as the "charismatic strongman," the "vox populi," or the voice of the pure people.

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